things’. Santaraksita defended the irreducibility of consciousness to the body’s material processes with ‘a different naturalistic account of cognition than the one put forth by the Carvaka’. Invited by the king of Tibet, where Buddhism had been introduced in the seventh century but had since floundered, Santaraksita also travelled to the country ‘to establish the first monastic university, Samye, and served as its abbot’.[20] Indeed, he epitomized Nalanda’s active outreach to foreign lands, which trained ‘specialists in Tibetan and Chinese who prepared translations into these languages and who themselves went out as missionaries’.[21]

Other philosopher monks of renown associated with Nalanda include Kamalasila, Chandrapala, Gunamati, Sthiramati, Prabhamitra, Atisa Dipamkara and others, including many more named by Xuanzang. The Nalanda scholastics also esteemed Xuanzang. They beseeched him to stay and lured him with accolades and prestigious roles in their hierarchy. But he declined with this reply: ‘The Buddha established his doctrine so that it might be diffused to all lands. Who would wish to enjoy it alone, and to forget those who are not yet enlightened?’ Xuanzang’s memory lived on in India for scores of years, and he was long accorded a place in Indian temple paintings with his ‘hemp shoes, spoon and chop sticks mounted on multicolored clouds’.[22]

Xuanzang founded the Faxiang school of thought in China, whose ideas live on in Japanese Buddhism. Based on the Yogacara school, it focused on consciousness and posited that the world is only a representation of the mind. The Buddhist Tang emperor, Gaozong, supported Xuanzang’s later enterprise and even built a pagoda—now the Big Goose Pagoda of Xian—to house his translations (many still in use) and display in a small museum on site. Outside the entrance is an elegant modern statue of the man. The emperor was so upset when he heard of the monk’s death that he cancelled all audiences for three days.

The Decline of Buddhism in India

Buddhism had been receding in India since at least the seventh century, when Xuanzang saw abandoned and dilapidated monasteries. In the late eighth century, this decline accelerated with the rise of Adi Shankara, a